

# Class 7: Aspects of Social Movement Activity

Social movements and the media

Dr. Michael C. Zeller

# Agenda for the day

- Opening notes
- Opening questions
- Poll: movements and media
- Movements and (traditional) media coverage
- Social movements and social media
- Movements, media, and astroturfing
- Any questions, concerns, feedback for this class?

# Opening notes



# Presentation groups

December

January

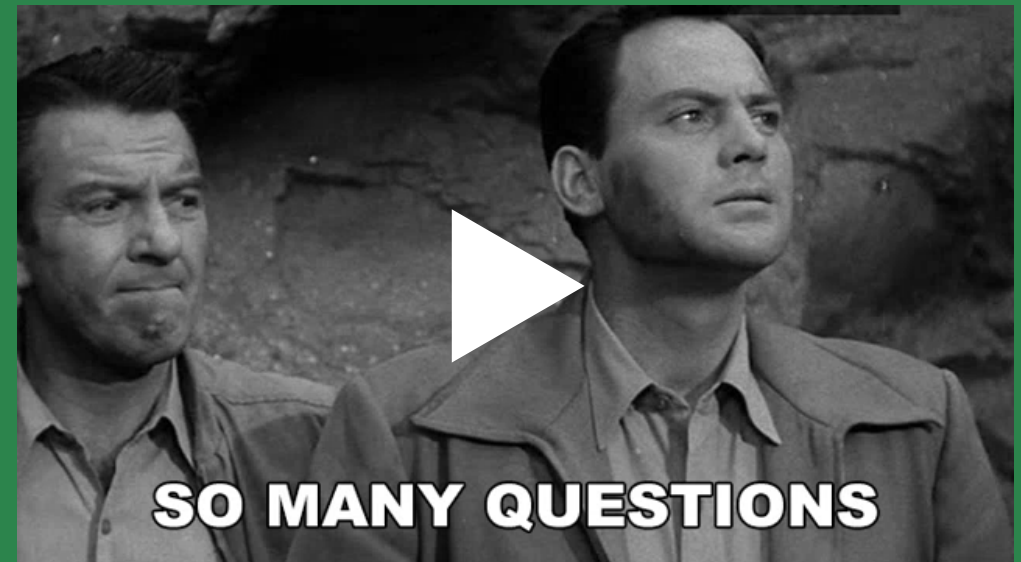
## Presentations line-up

| Date    | Presenters | Method |
|---------|------------|--------|
| 4 Dec:  |            | TBD    |
| 11 Dec: |            | TBD    |
| 18 Dec: |            | TBD    |



# Opening questions

- Where do you get your news?
- When you read the news (thinking only of 'traditional media' for the moment), what is reported, generally?



# Media: the translator of social movements

What are the mechanisms of...

- movements advancing their **frames** (*Class 3*),
- **mobilisation, recruitment, participation** (*Class 4*),
- **tactics** and **strategies** achieving results (*Class 6*)?

often it is **the media** (including social media)

how media covers a movement is often how most people know about it

- **big practical and theoretical stakes**
- often plays a **gatekeeper** role

# Past and present eras: a change of arena



*The Great Barricade at the Entrance of the Rue du Faubourg St. Antoine, from the Place de la Bastille.*





# Past and present eras: a change of arena



*The Great Barricade at the Entrance of the Rue du Faubourg St. Antoine, from the Place de la Bastille.*



- previous eras: direct action, confrontation between movements and authorities more common
  - here: barricade in Paris, 1848
- modern era: indirect contention filtered through **media** more common
  - here: press pack ahead of movement press conference in Hong Kong
  - ‘the whole world is watching’ era
    - the **prospect** (for movements) and **peril** (for targets/authorities) now?  
**the whole world may be watching**

# Poll: movements and media

**LMU**

LUDWIG-  
MAXIMILIANS-  
UNIVERSITÄT  
MÜNCHEN



Take the survey at

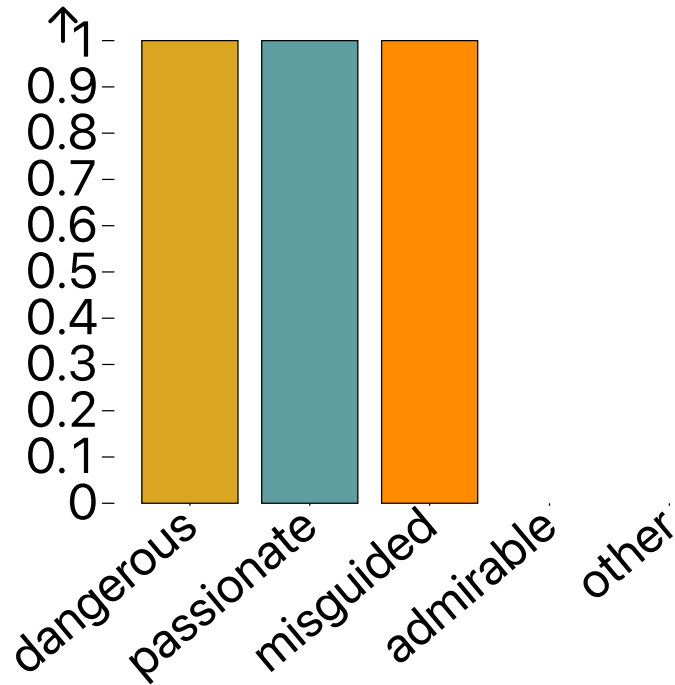
<https://forms.gle/ngepuqqzaFu8n>



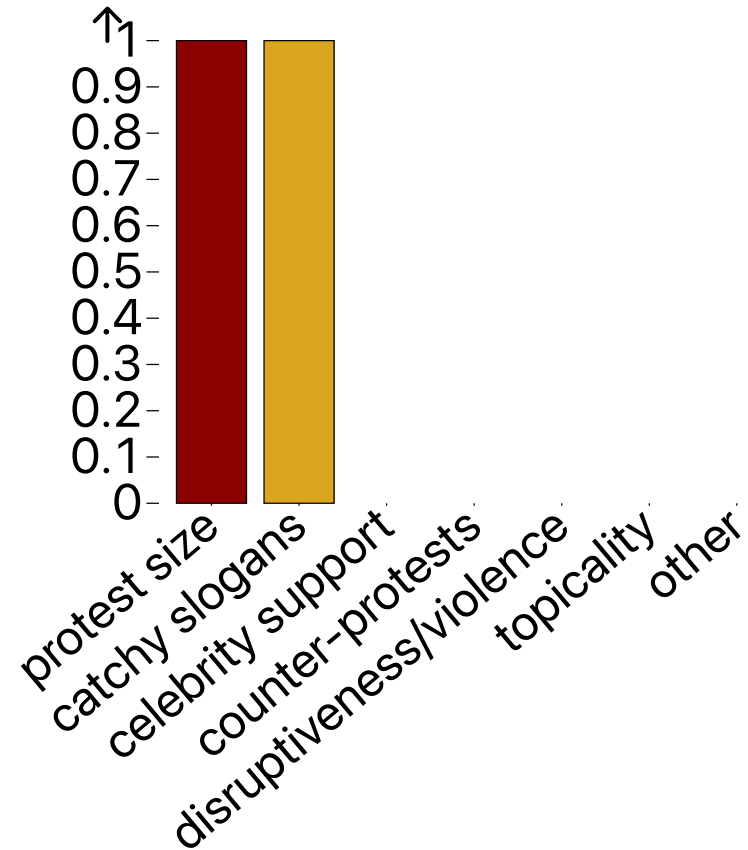
- ever personally supported a movement online?
  - how do media generally portray *protesters*?
  - what is most likely to help a movement get media coverage?
- 
- should movements tailor their messaging/framing to gain more attention?
  - is traditional media coverage still necessary for movement success in an age of social media?
  - does social media encourage 'slacktivism'?

# Poll results (Respondents: 3)

how do media generally portray *protesters*?



most likely to help a movement get media coverage?



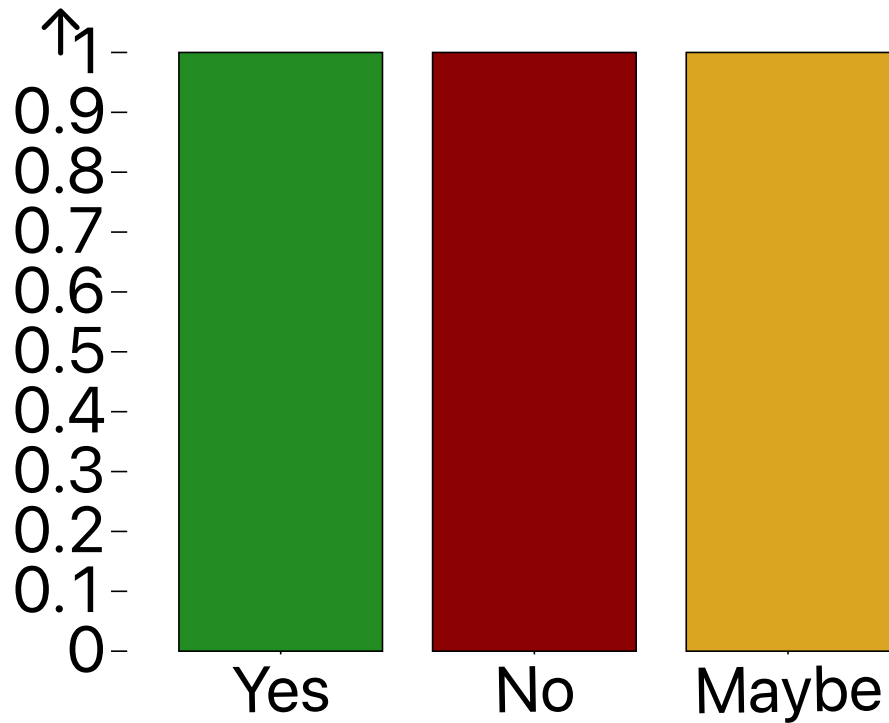




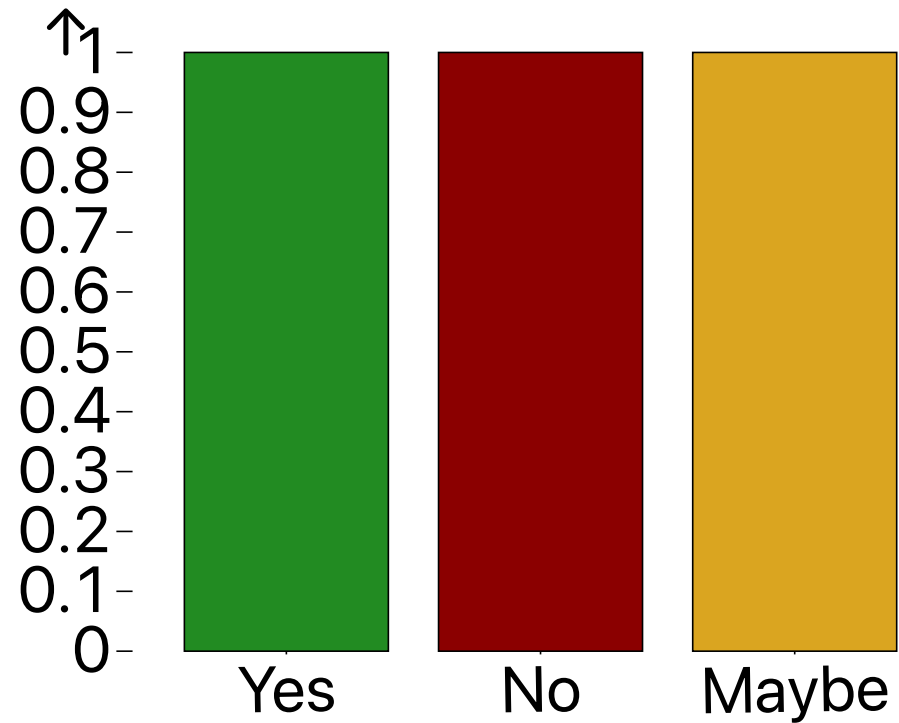
# Poll results - boosting media coverage

# Poll results - online

ever personally supported a  
movement online?



does social media encourage  
'slacktivism'?



# Movements and (traditional) medicine coverage

- (some) factors influencing media coverage
- Jennings and Saunders (2019)
  - research questions, importance
  - data and methods
  - hypotheses
  - results



# Movements and (traditional) media coverage

## *Factors that may affect media coverage*

- day of the week (McCarthy, Mcphail, and Smith 1996)
- other news events (set number of 'column inches')
- weather (Madestam et al. 2013)
- celebrities (Atkinson and DeWitt 2018)
- size of event, violence/disruptiveness, whether there is a counterdemonstration (Denardo 1985; McCarthy, Mcphail, and Smith 1996; Biggs 2018)

# Movements and (traditional) media coverage

## *Factors that may affect media coverage*

- size of event, violence/disruptiveness, whether there is a counterdemonstration (Denardo 1985; McCarthy, Mcphail, and Smith 1996; Biggs 2018)
  - larger protests get reported – duh!
  - **media attention cycles** (*topicality*) (McCarthy et al. 1996)
    - if Germany's energy is in the news, then energy/climate protests may get more attention
  - **counterdemonstrations** may help attract more attention (media bias for '*both sides*')

# Jennings and Saunders (2019) - RQs

- Why do some protests get reported on and others not?
- What protests get covered over the long term and why?
- Why? What's at stake?
  - **demonstrations** are **effective** when they not only hit newspaper headlines, but create a “**sustained shift in media focus, onto the issues that the demonstration raises**” (p. 2287)

- 48 street demonstrations in nine countries between 2009 - 2013
  - surveys – how do you think this is done?
  - Belgium, Czechia, Denmark, Germany, Netherlands, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, and United Kingdom
  - any important contextual considerations?

The design of our study is **large-N** (based on a sample of demonstrations, avoiding the tautology endemic to many studies of media attention to protest, which **select cases based on their being reported in the media**), at the same time as putting protest in context. (pp. 2293-4)



# Jennings and Saunders (2019) - data and methods



# Jennings and Saunders (2019) - hypotheses

| Feature                | Static                   | Dynamic                                     |
|------------------------|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Number of participants | larger = more coverage   | short- and long-term coverage               |
| Contentiousness        | high = more coverage     | short- and long-term coverage               |
| Exhibit violence       | violence = more coverage | short-term coverage, long-term losses/costs |
| Trigger event          | trigger = more coverage  | short-term coverage                         |

do these expectations make sense to you? do you disagree with any?

# Jennings and Saunders (2019) - reg table

**Table 3.** Dynamic Model of Contextual Predictors on Media Coverage of Protest Issues.

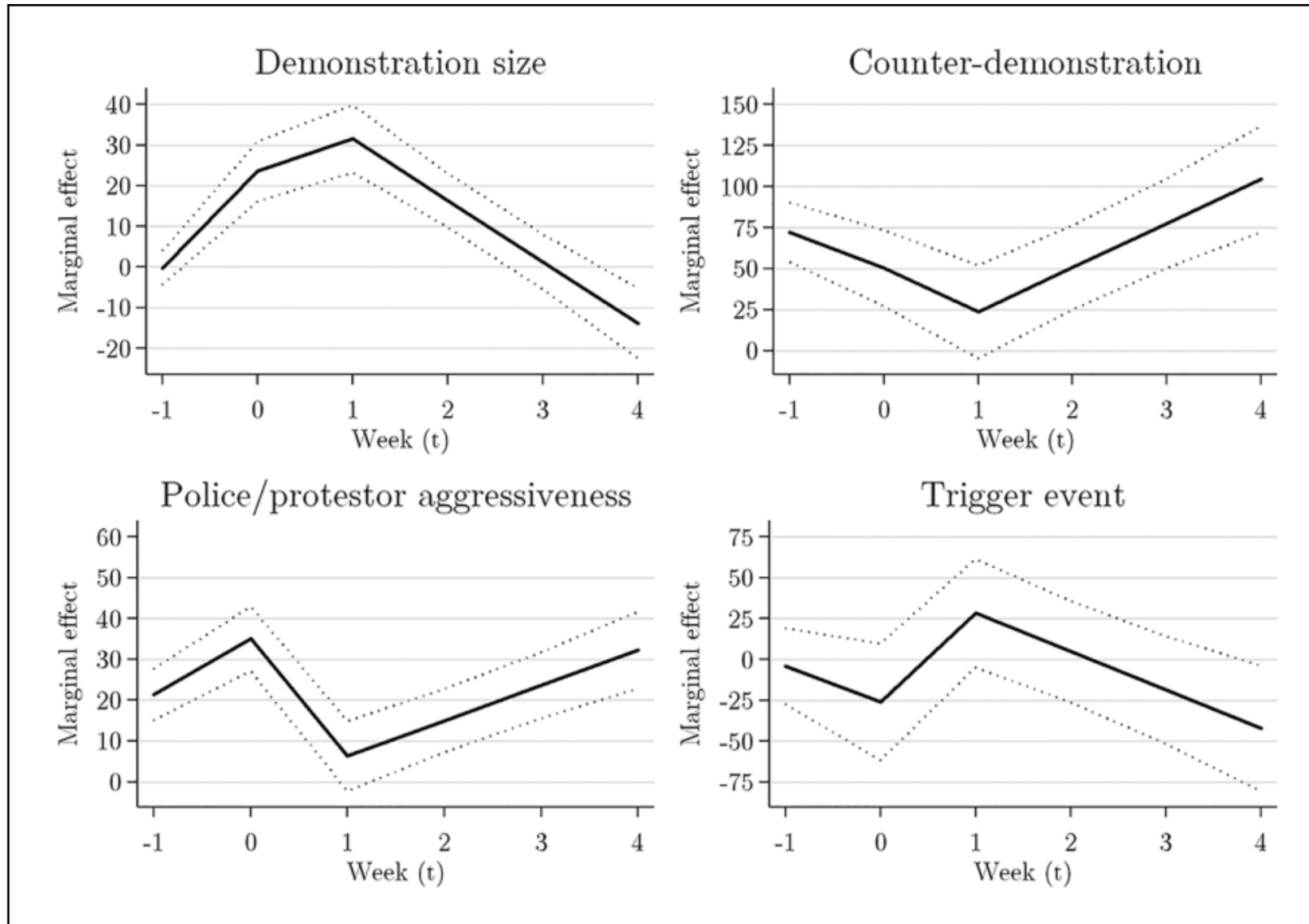
|                                            | MEDIA <sub>it</sub> |                    |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------------|--------------------|
| PULSE <sub>it</sub>                        | 16.73<br>(13.46)    | 7.25<br>(7.34)     |
| STEP <sub>it</sub>                         | 73.08<br>(21.74)**  | 54.74<br>(11.03)** |
| RAMP <sub>it</sub>                         | -21.91<br>(6.82)**  | -13.65<br>(3.68)** |
| tone <sub>i</sub>                          | 10.01<br>(10.77)    | 15.41<br>(13.94)   |
| size <sub>i</sub>                          | 2.26<br>(5.29)      | -0.18<br>(4.16)    |
| COUNTER <sub>i</sub>                       | 65.55<br>(10.75)**  | 72.25<br>(18.10)** |
| DEMPOL <sub>i</sub>                        | 27.28<br>(6.85)**   | 26.37<br>(7.81)**  |
| TRIGGER <sub>i</sub>                       | -7.00<br>(20.08)    | -3.99<br>(23.29)   |
| size <sub>i</sub> × PULSE <sub>it</sub>    |                     | 23.74<br>(7.44)**  |
| size <sub>i</sub> × STEP <sub>it</sub>     |                     | 46.87<br>(11.41)** |
| size <sub>i</sub> × RAMP <sub>it</sub>     |                     | -15.14<br>(3.64)** |
| COUNTER <sub>i</sub> × PULSE <sub>it</sub> |                     | -22.00<br>(21.89)  |
| COUNTER <sub>i</sub> × STEP <sub>it</sub>  |                     | -75.41<br>(35.55)* |
| COUNTER <sub>i</sub> × RAMP <sub>it</sub>  |                     | 26.93<br>(10.54)*  |
| DEMPOL <sub>i</sub> × PULSE <sub>it</sub>  |                     | 13.67<br>(5.99)*   |
| DEMPOL <sub>i</sub> × STEP <sub>it</sub>   |                     | -23.72<br>(9.25)*  |
| DEMPOL <sub>i</sub> × RAMP <sub>it</sub>   |                     | 8.66<br>(3.05)**   |
| TRIGGER <sub>i</sub> × PULSE <sub>it</sub> |                     | 19.75<br>(23.20)   |
| TRIGGER <sub>i</sub> × STEP <sub>it</sub>  |                     | 55.83<br>(38.03)   |

# Reading a regression table

Remember: regression is a tool for understanding a phenomenon as a linear function (generally)  $\rightarrow (y = mx + b)$

# Jennings and Saunders (2019) - reg table

# Jennings and Saunders (2019) - marginal effects

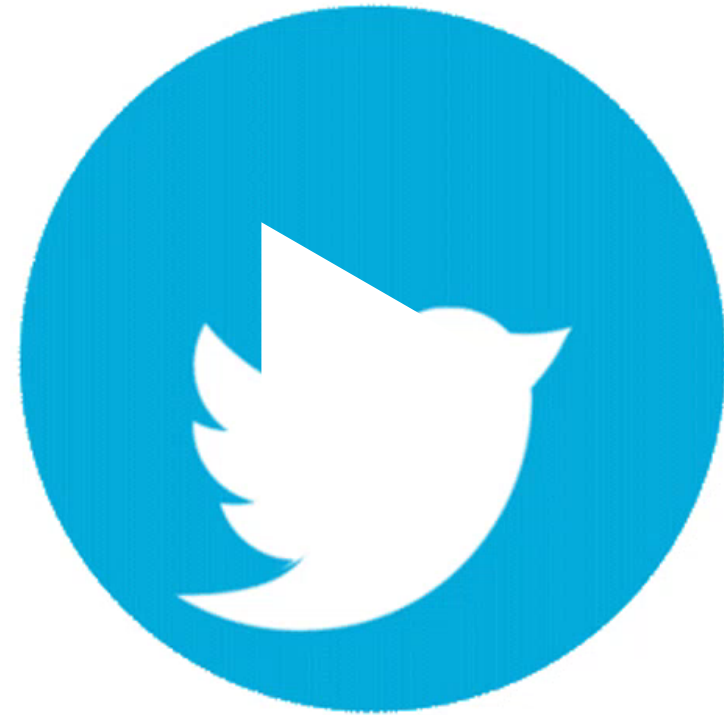


# Jennings and Saunders (2019) - conclusions

- demos increase media coverage, **but** effect decays quickly
  - practical importance? **'strike while the iron is hot'**
- large size and police aggressiveness **increase** media coverage
- counterdemos *significantly reduced media coverage* of protest issues in longer term
  - puzzling finding

# Social movements and social media

- from #hashtag to mobilisation
  - BLM example
- Slacktivism





# From #hashtag to mobilisation

(USA Today on BLM)

# From #hashtag to mobilisation

(USA Today on BLM)

social media breaks down traditional media **gatekeeper** roles

- helped BLM form **coalition** of K-Pop fans, Anonymous, celebrities, etc.
- enhanced BLM's 'narrative capacity' (i.e., efficacy in advancing **frames**, shifting status quo)
  - cf. 'disruptive capacity' and 'institutional/political capacity'

# Movements and social media - revisiting a debate

*Class 4: we listened to Tufekci and social media mobilisation and 'old-school organisation' - can attract more participants, but perhaps with less commitment*

# Movements, media, and astroturfing

- Torches of Freedom
- astroturfing
- knock-on effects



# Torches of Freedom

1929, Easter Sunday Parade: a Tabubruch? more emancipation for women?



# Movements, media, and astroturfing

**astroturfing** - manipulation of public sphere (media, information, movement scene)

- fake 'grassroots movements' are a common form of astroturfing
  - a way of harnessing the 'power of movement'
  - e.g., 'Tea Party movement' - a '*people's*' movement funded by Koch Industries
- any examples, instances of this in/around your case?

# Torches of Freedom

# Astroturfing: knock-on effects

- when movements are sometimes faked/manufactured, it undermines potential credibility of other movements
  - are people being ‘paid to protest’? who is ‘behind’ this protest?
  - questioning motives/genuineness of movements
    - **Letzte Generation:** funding from Climate Emergency Fund (U.S.), including Aileen Getty, heir of Getty Oil company
    - **Just Stop Oil (U.K.):** large amounts of funding from Climate Emergency Fund, from Dale Vince (green energy industrialist)
  - examples of conspiracy beliefs in U.S. (George Soros, Sandy Hook, etc.)



# Any questions, concerns, feedback for this class?

Anonymous feedback here: <https://forms.gle/AjHt6fcnwZxkSg4X8>

Alternatively, please send me an email: [m.zeller@lmu.de](mailto:m.zeller@lmu.de)

# References

- Atkinson, Matthew D., and Darin DeWitt. 2018. "Does Celebrity Issue Advocacy Mobilize Issue Publics?" *Political Studies*, no. 2. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0032321717751294>.
- Biggs, Michael. 2018. "Size Matters: Quantifying Protest by Counting Participants." *Sociological Methods and Research* 47 (3): 351–83. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0049124116629166>.
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- McCarthy, John D, Clark Mcphail, and Jackie Smith. 1996. "Images of Protest: Dimensions of Selection Bias in Media Coverage of Washington Demonstrations, 1982 and 1991." *American Sociological Review* 61 (3): 478–99.